

Species saved

Conservationists have used different methods to protect species from threats and help them recover, including setting aside protected wild areas, stopping hunting, or taking animals into captivity so they can breed safely there. Many species that were once on the brink of extinction have been saved, and today the populations of many of those species are growing.



Blue whale

Once relentlessly hunted, the blue whale became one of the world's rarest species as its numbers plunged in the early 1900s. It is still endangered but, since a hunting ban in 1966, whale populations are now increasing.



Mauritius kestrel

In the 1970s, deforestation and introduced animals, such as mongooses and cats, meant that this island bird of prey was down to just four individuals—making it the world's rarest bird. They were taken into captivity for breeding, which has raised the population to hundreds.



Sea otter

The thick, protective fur of the sea otter made this animal a target for hunters: it was hunted until there were just a thousand or so individuals left. A hunting ban and better protection of the seas helped it recover.



Flying high

With a wingspan of 10 ft (3 m), the California condor soars to heights of up to 15,000 ft (4,600 m). It is the biggest flying bird in North America.

California condor

Hunting and lead poisoning helped drive North America's biggest bird of prey to extinction in the wild in 1978. But captive breeding increased numbers, and birds could be released back into protected areas.



A horse apart

Its stocky body, high mane, white nose, and shorter legs set the Przewalski's horse apart from domesticated horses.

Przewalski's horse

The world's only truly wild species of horse was hunted to extinction but survived in zoos, and today it is the focus of a captive breeding program. In the 1990s, some were released back into their wild habitat in Mongolia.

**100,000 NATIONAL PARKS
AND WILDLIFE RESERVES
EXIST IN THE WORLD TODAY**

**12% OF EARTH'S
LAND IS
PROTECTED**

Extinction in the wild

For some species in captivity, there is no true wild for them to return to. The last wild Père David's deer probably died in China more than 200 years ago, but some animals survived in a hunting park and were brought to England. The fenced herds alive today are all descended from these.

